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THE PROFOUND MEANING OF NONSENSE

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A LOOK INTO SUKUMARY RAY'S WORK

Sukumar Roy – The socio-cultural inheritance of his literary works

- He portrays the peak of the Bengali Kolkata based colonial middle class –both collaborator and critic
- His background shows that he upgraded from the educated aspirant middle class to the established higher class through adoption of his grandfather –Upendra Kishor
- Thus class was major factor in his limelight gathering. – From professional to zamindar profession, the perfect colonial combo elite

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- Upendra used his skills to become U.Roy –a printing specialist and later editor of Sandesh the first children’s magazine that was “global” in outreach and high quality
- Children were the perfect audience for the “reformed” colonial collaborationist stance –the dominant one in liberal society
- It was a period when Kolkata was facing contest from the margins – the vast East Bengal which Upendara had left behind
- It’s within this matrix of Bengal-Kolkata- London that Sukumar Roy can be looked into

Sukumar Roy and his imagination

- Continuation of his heritage –main work is in the footsteps of Upendra Kishor
- He went to London in 1912 –Print technology, photography etc. Practical skills not literature
- Supported Tagore and introduced his work to the British -1912-3
- Returned to Kolkata and began working on U.Press and Sandesh

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- The hybrid imagination was in all his work – the use of satire as a tool of expression
- Familiarity with Western works and literature including Lewis Carol , Jonathan swift and others
- Art and culture clubs and focus on work for children and publishing
- The nature of his imagination has multiple interpretations

The Hybrid and the colonial critic

- Using “Nonsense” was part of his creativity and literary strategy from early on

Did it free him from socio-political loyalty?

- “Bhalo re Bhalo” poem says everything is good means no bad so nothing has any value
- His earliest prose works was critical of authority –

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- He was part of the hybrid “Brahmo Samaj “but was critical of its leadership
- Critical of the colonial elite rather than colonialism ?
- The “Tagore syndrome” affecting the Kolkata babu class of the mid-20th century
- Depicted hybridity and its contradictions uniquely and mainstreamed literary satire

Political reality of colonial literature

- Middle class elite based on colonialism but questioning it also when affected
- Not always aware of emerging historical forces such as East Bengal and majority population
- Like Tagore underestimated 1905-11's impact, also 1923 Bengal Pact
- Hybrid was social as he saw but political hybridity was conflicted which later dominated

Additional Study:

- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kRg1WbFvXqo>
- <https://armchairjournal.com/the-political-sense-behind-the-non-sense-deciphering-abol-tabol/>
- <https://www.thedailystar.net/literature/sukumar%E2%80%99s-birthday-164875>
- <https://www.bangla-kobita.com/sukumar/bhalore-bhalo/>
- <https://www.kolkata-online.com/bangla/sukumar/khichuri.html>